

GUIDE · AFTER A LOSS

After the loss of a spouse: *a planning checklist.*

The hardest days are not the right time for complicated decisions. This checklist organizes the months that follow into three deliberate phases, so nothing essential is missed and nothing urgent is rushed.

BY Derek Carrillo, Esq. FIRM Premier Estate Planning READING 7 minutes UPDATED Spring 2026

Move at a humane pace. The items below are a guide, not a to-do list to finish in a week. Your advisor and the attorneys at PEP can carry much of this with you.

IMMEDIATE FOCUS · FIRST DAYS AND WEEKS

- ☐ Take care of yourself and your family first.
- ☐ Create a central folder — physical or digital — for documents.
- ☐ Notify your financial advisor, attorney, tax professional, and insurance agent.
- ☐ Order death certificates (request 10–25 certified copies).
- ☐ Gather key personal and financial documents.
- ☐ Review life insurance and funeral or memorial arrangements.
- ☐ Arrange access to funds for short-term living expenses.
- ☐ Notify the Social Security Administration and the employer, if applicable.

SHORT-TERM FOLLOW-UP · FIRST 1–3 MONTHS

- ☐ Review employer benefits and any final compensation.
- ☐ Secure and retitle bank and investment accounts.
- ☐ Review and address credit cards and outstanding loans.
- ☐ Update real-estate and vehicle titles.
- ☐ Update utilities, subscriptions, and automatic payments.
- ☐ Review and manage digital accounts and access.

LONGER-TERM PLANNING · 3-12 MONTHS

- ☐ Revisit your overall financial and investment strategy.
- ☐ Plan for retirement income and insurance proceeds.
- ☐ Inventory estate assets and household property.
- ☐ Begin estate administration and any required tax filings.
- ☐ Update your own will and healthcare documents.
- ☐ Hold a family financial meeting.
- ☐ Review charitable, legacy, and educational planning.
- ☐ Continue attending to your own well-being.

YOU ARE NOT ALONE IN THIS

These decisions are easier with steady guidance. Your financial advisor and the team at Premier Estate Planning can help you work through each phase with care, and handle the legal steps on your behalf.

SCHEDULE A CONSULTATION

The conversation begins with a *thirty-minute call*.

Complimentary and confidential. We discuss your circumstances, outline a path forward, and quote a single flat fee in writing — before any work begins.

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